Alien Dimensions: The Shepherd's Wasteland

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Volume 1: The Collapse of Flesh

Chapter 1: The Singularity Descends

1. The Black Hole in the Data

The deep autumn wind of the Qinling Mountains carried a scent like ground rust as it squeezed forcibly through the fissures of Ghost Sorrow Canyon, stinging the skin like a blade.

Lin Shen wiped a sheen of sweat from his forehead. The salty liquid ran down his brow bone and into his eyes, stinging with a fiery burn. Squinting against the damnable afterglow of the setting sun, he adjusted the heavy 3D laser scanner set up before him.

"Lin, are you done gathering yet?"

Captain Zhang's gritty voice crackled over the walkie-talkie, mixed with the static hiss of current, sounding like someone chewing on gravel. "It's getting dark. That place is cursed; even the local hunters don't dare stay there overnight. Pull out, now."

"Last set of point cloud data. Five minutes," Lin Shen pressed the talk button and replied.

As a contractor for the Provincial Surveying and Mapping Institute, Lin Shen's job was monotonous and dry: carrying equipment weighing over fifty pounds, climbing every fold of the Qinling Mountains like a goat, all to fill in the final few blank spots for the government's "Digital Qinling" project.

The place he stood now had no name on the map; the coordinates simply displayed "Unnamed Valley." The vegetation here was tinted an uncomfortable shade of deep purple. It was quiet—too quiet. There was not even the chirping of insects, only the whistling sound of the wind passing through dead tree branches.

"Beep—Scan initiated."

The laser head fired hundreds of millions of invisible pulses, casting a shapeless net toward the vine-covered cliff face ahead. Lin Shen stared at the real-time imaging screen on his tablet. As the progress bar advanced, the contours of the rock were constructed bit by bit on the screen.

However, when the scan reached the center of the cliff, Lin Shen froze.

A black spot appeared in the center of the screen.

At first, he thought it was an instrument malfunction or a dead pixel. He rebooted the device, adjusted the frequency, and even switched to infrared imaging mode. But the black spot remained. In the data feedback from the laser radar, there were no reflection waves from that spot. Light went in like a drop in the ocean—vanishing without a trace, not even a whisper of an echo. It wasn't a shadow; it was the absolute void of data.

"Weird..." Lin Shen muttered to himself.

He picked up a fist-sized piece of granite from the ground, summoned all his strength, and threw it toward the position of the black spot. The stone traced a standard parabola in the air.

Whoosh—

There was no sound of impact. No sound of rolling rubble. The moment the stone touched that patch of air, it was as if an invisible eraser had simply wiped it out of this three-dimensional world.

Lin Shen held his breath. A chill shot from his tailbone straight to the crown of his skull, instantly freezing the cold sweat on his back.

2. Vacuum Leak

Logic told him he should turn around and run, report these coordinates to the National Security Bureau or a research institute. But that damnable human curiosity, like a self-destruct program carved into the genes, drove him to move his legs forward.

He approached the cliff face, step by step. Five meters... three meters... one meter.

Upon closer observation, the air there displayed an extremely subtle distortion, like the heat waves rising from an asphalt road in summer, yet there was no heat source around.

Trembling, Lin Shen reached out his right hand. His fingertip inched closer to that nothingness. The instant his fingerprint touched that invisible "membrane"—

HUM!!

There was no sensation of ice or heat. A terrifying low-frequency vibration traveled along the bones of his fingertips, ignoring the barrier of muscle and nerves, and drilled directly into his brain marrow like an electric drill.

The sensation was indescribable, as if someone had shoved a high-power subwoofer inside his skull and turned the volume to the maximum.

Warning: Unauthorized biological entity. Horizon Sheath startup failed... Vacuum Zero-Point Energy leakage: 0.0001%.

It wasn't a sound; it was a stream of information exploding directly onto Lin Shen's cerebral cortex. Immediately following it was devastating pain.

"Ahhh—!!!"

Lin Shen let out a wretched scream. His entire body was blasted backward, slamming heavily onto the gravel ground.

He clutched his left eye tightly with both hands. Warm, viscous liquid gushed madly from between his fingers. It wasn't tears; it was blood and vitreous fluid oozing out after his eye withstood hyper-dimensional pressure in an instant. Even a leakage of one ten-thousandth of that energy, for a fragile carbon-based lifeform, was equivalent to staring directly at a nuclear explosion.

"My eye... my eye..."

Lin Shen rolled on the ground in agony, his stomach convulsing. He vomited bile that tasted of rust—a sign of internal bleeding from the shock.

3. Triple Pupil and the Dark Side of the Moon

The intense pain lasted a full minute before slightly receding, turning into constant tinnitus and vertigo. Gasping for air, soaked in cold sweat and blood, Lin Shen tentatively opened his traumatized left eye.

The world had changed.

The originally dim Qinling Canyon was now covered in countless gray, complex geometric lines in his vision. Those were the structural lines of space, the longitudes and latitudes of dimensions.

And when he raised his head and looked at the sky, he saw a scene he would never forget for the rest of his life. Through the atmosphere, through the clouds, he saw the celestial body 380,000 kilometers away.

It wasn't the moon.

It wasn't the silver disk that poets entrusted with their longing, nor the cratered, silent rock seen in astronomical telescopes. Under the gaze of his mutated left eye—where the pupil had now split into a bizarre triple-nested structure—the rock surface of the moon became as transparent as glass.

He saw the interior of the moon.

It was a massive, precise, roaring hollow metal megastructure. Countless black pipes with diameters exceeding a hundred kilometers crisscrossed like pulsating blood vessels. Giant mechanical arms moved slowly beneath the lunar mantle, grabbing glowing debris and throwing it into furnaces.

That debris... Lin Shen squinted his bleeding eye, trying desperately to see clearly. It was shattered bronze spaceships, broken stone steles, the corpses of countless civilizations he had never seen before.

This was an Interstellar Slaughterhouse. It was also a massive garbage processing center.

"What... what the hell is that..." Lin Shen's brain nearly crashed, unable to process such a grand visual impact.

4. Forced Binding

Just then, the "black hole" on the cliff suddenly collapsed.

A transparent, triangular crystal, only the size of a fingernail, floated slowly out of the void. As if attracted by the scent of Lin Shen's blood, it traced a strange trajectory in the air and flew straight at him.

Lin Shen wanted to dodge, but his body was uncontrollable due to the shock he had just suffered. The crystal hovered over the palm of his right hand, vibrating at a high frequency, emitting a buzzing sound that made his teeth ache.

It didn't ask. It offered no contract. It stabbed directly in.

"Urgh!"

Lin Shen watched as the crystal melted into the flesh of his palm like a drop of water merging into the sea, facing no obstruction. Immediately, a domineering force surged upstream along the neural network of his arm. Data was forcibly written into his hippocampus, and vast amounts of knowledge not belonging to humanity were violently downloaded:

[Dimensional Vision]: Activated. [Space Tear]: Locked (Physical strength insufficient). [Coordinate Displacement]: Locked.

This wasn't finding a treasure; this was being forcibly parasitized by a high-dimensional parasite!

Host vital signs weak... Initiating emergency jump procedure.

The cold stream of information sounded again. Before Lin Shen could curse, the space around him cracked open like a broken mirror. Gravity vanished. He felt as though his internal organs were grabbed by a giant invisible hand. His entire person was sucked into a bizarre, colorful tunnel.

The wind, the trees, the sunset of the Qinling Mountains—all vanished in this instant. Replacing them was a deathly silence, and the suffocating chill of a vacuum.

His destination—that celestial purgatory hanging in the sky, devouring the bones of civilizations: The Moon.

Chapter 2: The Lunar Slaughterhouse

1. Engine Sounds in the Grave

Gravity acted like a drunk child, instantly flipping direction.

Lin Shen thought he would smash onto hard rock, but what welcomed him was a pool of viscous, cold fluid that smelled of metal and blood. He struggled to surface, his lungs burning violently from inhaling some oxygen-rich inert gas, coughing up strings of pink foam.

"Cough... cough..."

He wiped the slime from his face and struggled to open his functioning right eye. His left eye was still in severe pain and could only blurrily sense light.

His vision gradually cleared. There was no sunlight here. The light source came from thousands of meters above his head—where countless giant cylindrical containers floated, glowing with a ghostly blue light.

Lin Shen saw his environment clearly. This was indeed the interior of the moon, but it had nothing to do with the high-tech alien bases of his imagination. This place looked more like an interstellar-class slaughterhouse floor, or the digestive tract of some colossal organism.

Giant black mechanical arms hung from the dark dome, swimming through the air like steel centipedes. What they grabbed wasn't ore, but the corpses of civilizations. Lin Shen saw a broken bronze giant ship—legendary Qin Dynasty style, with seal script characters still carved on the hull—being ruthlessly dismantled, twisted, and fed into a crusher. He also saw stone aircraft resembling Mayan style being tossed into furnaces like trash.

"This isn't a shelter..." Lin Shen grabbed a translucent pipe next to him, inside of which flowed a golden liquid. He trembled. "This is a garbage dump."

Thump... Thump...

Rhythmic vibrations came from the metal deck beneath his feet. That was the roar of the moon's engine. Every vibration felt like it was stepping on his heart.

2. Fuel and Code

Warning: Carbon-based lifeform detected. ID: Earth-Homo Sapiens (Civilization Cycle 5).

A cold voice exploded directly in his cerebral cortex. This time, because the [Dimensional Pick] in his hand had automatically activated the [Thought Wave Resonance] function, Lin Shen didn't need translation; he directly understood the meaning behind these chaotic syllables.

"Who?" Lin Shen looked up sharply, his right hand tightly gripping the crystal embedded in his palm.

"I am the Lunar Central Processing System. Current Task: Cleaning up Cycle 4 (Atlantis) residual data. Preparing Cycle 5 (Modern Humanity) harvest plan."

As the voice fell, a "furnace" in the distance roared open. Lin Shen watched in horror as countless translucent shadows—some kind of humanoid spirits—were swept into the furnace by a massive suction force. They screamed soundlessly; it was the frequency of despair. The moment they touched the singularity core of the furnace, these souls were forcibly stripped of memories and emotions, decomposed into the purest particles of energy light. Those points of light flowed along the pipes, transported to the deep reaches of the universe.

"What is that?" Lin Shen felt his stomach convulse, the bile he had just swallowed threatening to come up again.

"Fuel," the System's voice was calm to the point of atrocity. "The 'self-awareness' and 'emotional fluctuations' generated by lower civilizations are high-quality, high-entropy fuel required for high-dimensional navigation. Your love, hate, and fear are hot commodities in the interstellar market."

Lin Shen's brain went blank. Humanity's thousands of years of history, love and hate, war and peace... in the eyes of these higher existences, were merely to make the coal burn a little brighter? All epics were nothing but the crackling sound before combustion.

3. The Warden's Shackles

Suddenly, several slender mechanical tentacles shot out from the darkness, fast enough that the naked eye couldn't track them.

Splurt!

The probes at the tips of the tentacles pierced into Lin Shen's limbs and spine.

"Ah!!"

Lin Shen screamed. The probes didn't inject poison; they connected directly to his neural network.

Entity carries [Dimensional Pick]. Logic self-check... Confirmed: Previous Warden deceased. System protocol transfer. Congratulations, No. 9527. You have acquired 'Warden' clearance for the Earth Sector.

From today, you are responsible for maintaining the stability of the Earth Pasture, ensuring the 'livestock' grow healthily until Harvest Day arrives.

With its pronouncement, countless massive streams of data were forcibly stuffed into Lin Shen's brain: Earth's surveillance network, the control codes for the gravity lock, and tutorials on how to "fatten up" human civilization.

"Fuck your Warden!" Lin Shen exploded.

He didn't come here to be a collaborator or a traitor. He thought of the wind in the Qinling Mountains, thought of the bowl of noodles in his rental apartment. He would never be an accomplice.

The injured triple pupil in his left eye spun wildly. The newly acquired authority was instinctively activated. He no longer saw the world with naked eyes; he saw the "seams" of this slaughterhouse. Space was not continuous; it was a jigsaw puzzle made of countless fragile facets.

As long as he broke one of them...

4. The Price of Broken Bones

"Open... for me!"

Lin Shen roared, focusing his entire will on the Pick in his right hand.

Active Skill Activated: [Space Tear] (Level 2). Warning: Physical strength insufficient. Horizon Sheath only 50% deployed.

Buzz!

A layer of pitch-black, non-reflective spherical film instantly wrapped his right hand. It was a miniature event horizon. He felt his hand disappear, turning into a black hole capable of swallowing everything. He slashed viciously at the void in front of him.

There was no resistance. The solid space of the lunar core was torn open like a thin sheet of paper, revealing a pitch-black rift. On the other side of the rift was the familiar blue atmosphere of Earth.

But in that instant, the price was exacted.

The sheath blocked the annihilation energy of the void, but the gravitational shear wave generated by tearing space vibrated madly inside the sheath.

Snap!

A crisp sound of bone fracturing that set one's teeth on edge. Lin Shen clearly felt the ulna and radius of his right arm snap at the same time. The broken bone shards pierced the periosteum, and intense pain swept through his body like an electric current. Not only that, due to the conduction of the shockwave, the skin of his right arm instantly turned purple-black—tens of thousands of capillaries under the skin burst in that single second.

"Arghhh!!"

Lin Shen nearly passed out from the pain, cold sweat instantly soaking his entire body. But he didn't stop. The mechanical tentacles had been severed by the spatial rift, and alarms blared.

"Catch him! Illegal escape!"

Before more mechanical arms could encircle him, Lin Shen cradled his ruined right arm and dove headfirst into that pitch-black rift.

5. Return from Hell

Chaotic lights and shadows flew past him. The moment the weightlessness vanished, gravity slammed him ruthlessly onto the ground.

Thud!

Dust flew.

Lin Shen lay on the cold concrete floor, gasping for air. With every breath, his chest hurt like a bellows being pulled. His nose filled with the familiar smell of dust, and the scent of cooking oil from the neighbor's stir-fry.

He struggled to raise his head.

In front of him was a security door with a faded "Fortune" (Fu) sticker. Warm yellow light spilled out from the crack in the door.

That was the apartment he rented in Xi'an. He was back. He had returned from the hell 380,000 kilometers away to the human world. But he knew that this so-called "human world" was nothing more than a pigsty that hadn't reached slaughter time yet.

Lin Shen tried to stand up, but the intense pain in his right arm made him stumble and lean against the wall. Blood dripped from his cuff, smashing into dark red flowers on the floor. From inside the door came the sound of slippers walking, and Xu Weiyang humming a song.

Lin Shen bit his lip hard, refusing to let out a cry of pain. Using his uninjured left hand, he tremblingly pulled a pack of tissues from his pocket and desperately wiped the blood and lunar slime from his face. He had to disguise himself. For the person inside that door, he had to keep that hell outside.

He took a deep breath, adjusted his face into an expression uglier than crying, and then raised his left hand to gently knock on the door.

Knock, knock, knock.

These three knocks exhausted the last bit of strength he had as a mortal man.

Chapter 3: The Last Supper

1. The Fake Bunker

Click.

The spring latch of the old lock made a crisp sound as it retracted. The security door opened from the inside.

Xu Weiyang poked her head out, wearing loose pajamas printed with SpongeBob SquarePants and still holding a spatula in her hand. A look of suspicion was plastered on her face. Warm yellow light spilled out from behind her, illuminating the dim dust of the hallway and shining on Lin Shen's pale face.

"Standing guard at the door? I could hear your heavy breathing from inside." She crinkled her nose and leaned in to sniff him. "You smell like earth... didn't you go to the Qinling Mountains for surveying? Why do you look like you just crawled out of a grave?"

Lin Shen leaned against the doorframe, not daring to put his center of gravity on his broken right arm. He looked at Xu Weiyang. In his left eye—that newly mutated Eye of Truth, which hadn't yet fully adapted to three-dimensional light—Xu Weiyang was no longer just the girl who would wake up half an hour early for discounted eggs at the supermarket.

Her entire body radiated a soft, warm orange halo. That was the frequency of her soul. In that cold slaughterhouse on the moon, a soul of this hue was marked as "Premium Fuel", signifying kindness, optimism, and vigorous vitality. If thrown into the furnace, it would extract the purest high-entropy energy.

"What's wrong? Did you turn stupid?" Xu Weiyang waved her hand in front of his eyes.

Lin Shen snapped back to reality and pulled her into his arms with his uninjured left hand.

"Hey! You're all sweaty! The oil is going to burn!" Xu Weiyang complained with her mouth, but her body softened, and she gently patted his back. "You must be exhausted, right? Go wash your hands; the noodles will be ready in a second."

At the moment of the embrace, Lin Shen's right arm was inevitably squeezed. Pain like a red-hot iron rod stabbed into his bone marrow. His body trembled violently, and cold sweat instantly soaked his back. But he gritted his teeth and didn't make a sound.

He greedily inhaled the scent of the cheap Bee & Flower shampoo in her hair. That was the smell of the human world, of hearth and home; it was his only antidote at the edge of hell.

"Nothing." Lin Shen let go, his voice raspy as if he had swallowed gravel. "Just... a little hungry."

2. Fear Only God Knows

The dining table was a second-hand folding table, covered with a newspaper from last year. Two bowls of braised beef noodles, topped with a few leaves of emerald green bok choy, and two fried eggs with edges burnt to a golden crisp. Steam rose up, carrying the scent of coriander and aged vinegar, instantly washing away the cold mechanical roar in Lin Shen's mind. And, of course, two cans of Coke.

Lin Shen sat down, his right hand hanging below the table, and clumsily picked up his chopsticks with his left hand.

"The landlord called again today. He said the rent is going up by two hundred next quarter." Xu Weiyang picked at her noodles, rambling on. "I told him the water pipes in this broken house are leaking, and he still has the nerve to raise the price. Oh right, my idiot supervisor rejected my proposal again today, insisting on some 'colorful black'..."

She talked about these trivial matters with dancing eyebrows, occasionally taking an indignant bite of her fried egg.

Lin Shen lowered his head and ate large mouthfuls of noodles, drinking Coke in between. Due to the spatial shock earlier, his esophagus and stomach walls were covered in micro-tears. Every mouthful of hot noodles he swallowed felt like he was swallowing burning charcoal. But he ate fast, and he ate hard.

In the past, he found these naggy complaints annoying. He thought the universe was so vast and dreams were so far away—why be trapped by a few hundred yuan of rent? But now, as he chewed, he fought back the sourness in his eyes.

Even "worrying about rent" was an extremely luxurious privilege. Because only those who were alive, free, and not yet treated as fuel had the right to worry about rent. Overhead, 380,000 kilometers away, the souls of countless once-glorious civilizations were screaming as they turned to ash.

Xu Weiyang didn't know that the reason she could sit here securely and curse her supervisor was that a giant cage protected—and imprisoned—Earth. And the man sitting across from her had just obtained the key to this cage and was about to exile himself to break it.

"What's wrong with you?"

Xu Weiyang finally noticed something was wrong. Lin Shen was eating too urgently, too viciously, as if he would never eat again in his life. Moreover, his face was covered in sweat and tears.

Lin Shen looked up. In that instant, the triple pupil in his eye quickly receded, leaving only a human disguise.

"Too spicy." He pointed at the red oil in the bowl and squeezed out a smile that was uglier than crying. "This chili is too strong. I choked."

Xu Weiyang paused, then handed him a tissue, laughing out loud. "Look at you. I'll put less next time."

Next time.

Lin Shen's heart felt like it was fiercely squeezed by an invisible hand. There was no next time.

3. Cutting the Tail to Survive

After eating, Xu Weiyang went to wash the dishes. The sound of rushing water echoed in the small room.

Lin Shen walked into the bedroom and, using his left hand, struggled to pull his dusty tactical backpack out from under the bed. He began to pack. He only took a few changes of clothes, a multi-functional survival knife, and that copy of *A Brief History of Time* he hadn't finished reading. He poured all the painkillers into a single bottle and stuffed it into his inner pocket.

When Xu Weiyang walked into the bedroom wiping her hands, she saw Lin Shen standing by the window with the bag on his back. The atmosphere froze instantly.

"Field work again?" The smile vanished from Xu Weiyang's face, replaced by a flash of loneliness in her eyes. "You just got back, and you have to leave? How many days this time?"

Lin Shen turned around. He didn't dare look her in the eyes. Although the "High-Dimensional Radiation" on his body was temporarily suppressed by his mortal flesh, long-term exposure would still make Xu Weiyang sick. He was now a walking Chernobyl reactor. He had to get far away.

"Not a few days." Lin Shen's voice was terribly calm. It was the first time the divinity of the "King of All Souls" overpowered his humanity. "It's a confidential project. Maybe... three years. Maybe five."

Xu Weiyang was stunned. "What kind of project takes so long? You can't even make a phone call?"

"No. It's closed management." Lin Shen told a clumsy lie, but his tone allowed no doubt. "Weiyang, this is an opportunity for me. After this project, I can get a government position, and we'll have money to buy a house."

Xu Weiyang fell silent. She stared fixedly at Lin Shen, at his right hand that hung trembling slightly by his side, at his eyes that looked at the floor to avoid her gaze. After a long time, she lowered her head and gave a soft laugh.

"Lin Shen, when you lie, your left thumb always picks at the seam of your pants."

Lin Shen's body stiffened.

Xu Weiyang looked up. Her eyes were red, but there were no tears. She was a smart girl; she sensed a resolute chill coming from Lin Shen—it wasn't a change of heart, but some massive despair she couldn't understand.

"Although I don't know what trouble you've gotten into..." Xu Weiyang walked up and straightened his collar, her fingers gently brushing over the button on his chest. "But if you think leaving is for my own good, then get out."

She took the salary card she had just received out of her pocket and stuffed it into Lin Shen's jacket pocket. "The password is your birthday. The poor stay home, the rich travel the road. Don't starve to death out there."

4. Only the Moon Saw

Lin Shen didn't know how he walked out of that neighborhood. He didn't look back. He was afraid that if he looked back and saw the figure crying on the windowsill, all the psychological defenses he had built would collapse in an instant.

The midnight streets were empty. The autumn wind swept up fallen leaves, making a rustling sound. Standing under a streetlamp, Lin Shen finally couldn't hold it anymore. He leaned against the pole and slid to the ground. He took the bank card out of his pocket and pressed it against his chest. That was a mortal's body temperature, and his last anchor in this world.

"Hoo..."

He let out a long breath and swallowed two more painkillers. Then, he raised his head and looked at the night sky.

That bright, round moon hung in the sky like a cold, silver giant eye, ruthlessly watching this ant who had just crawled out of the cage. In the eyes of ordinary people, it was the bright moon that carried thoughts of longing. In Lin Shen's eyes, it was a millstone of bones waiting to devour the Earth.

Lin Shen used his uninjured left hand to push off the ground and stand up. Facing the moon, he slowly raised his middle finger.

"Watch this Earth closely."

He spoke coldly to the void, and to the System that was monitoring his thoughts. "If she loses a single hair... I will fold your galaxy, star by star, into trash."

He tightened his grip on the Dimensional Pick in his right hand.

"Open."

Buzz...

The black Horizon Sheath emerged again, wrapping around his broken body. Space folding initiated. Lin Shen's figure vanished instantly in the twisted light and shadow, leaving only a fallen leaf under the streetlamp, shredded by a vortex that appeared out of thin air.

The wind stopped. The world returned to deathly silence, as if no one had ever been there.

Volume 2: The Law of the Dark Forest

Chapter 4: The Dirty Trade in Orion

1. The Abscess of Betelgeuse

The moment the falling sensation disappeared, Lin Shen thought he had fallen into a pool of strong acid.

"Cough... cough... *retch*..."

He knelt on the ground, dry heaving violently. There was no air here, only a mixed medium filled with static electricity, ozone, and high concentrations of pheromones. It didn't need to be breathed; it drilled directly into the blood vessels through the pores, bringing a nauseating hallucinogenic effect.

Lin Shen struggled to lift his head. In that instant, he was so shocked by the sight before him that he forgot to breathe.

Directly overhead, a massive, dying Red Supergiant (Betelgeuse) occupied two-thirds of the sky. It pulsed irregularly like a festering heart, spewing deadly stellar winds in all directions. And in the turbulence of the stellar wind, tens of thousands of broken islands floated. They weren't rocks, but

the corpses of various giant creatures, fragments of abandoned Dyson spheres, and space junk forcibly glued together by gravity fields.

This was Orion Arm Trade Node 7, commonly known as "Betelgeuse's Abscess."

Lin Shen stood on the spine of some unknown leviathan. Around him were bustling "market goers": silicon-based lifeforms resembling smoke selling screaming metal cans; arthropods with compound eyes haggling over prices, with carbon-based cubs crying in cages beside them.

Zzzzt—

High-intensity cosmic radiation pricked Lin Shen's skin like needles. His broken right arm was now in excruciating pain. Without armor protection, a mortal body wouldn't last ten minutes here.

"Must... find equipment..." Lin Shen gritted his teeth, his left Eye of Truth searching through the chaotic energy streams. At the highest point of this chaotic garbage heap, there was a crystal spire emitting a pure white light. It was the only place not covered by radioactive dust.

2. The Arrogance of the Crystal Sage

Lin Shen pulled his bloodstained rain jacket tighter and stumbled through the market. He passed a stall where a lizard-like merchant tried to reach out and grab his backpack. Lin Shen turned his head sharply. A cold light flashed in the bizarre triple pupil of his left eye, and the Dimensional Pick in his hand emitted a low-frequency hum. The lizard merchant sensed the oppression from a higher dimension, retracted its claws in fear, and retreated while hissing.

Lin Shen didn't engage. He walked straight into the crystal spire. Inside the tower, it was as quiet as a tomb, and the air smelled faintly of mint. Behind the counter floated a massive, flawless polyhedral crystal. It had no facial features, but Lin Shen could feel thousands of gazes shooting out from every facet of the crystal, dissecting his thoughts like dissecting a frog.

"A rare guest."

An elegant voice sounded directly in Lin Shen's mind, like a chorus of pipe organs. "A newly awakened, wild Earth Warden. You have the nostalgic, stale smell of the Moon on you, and... the crisp sound of broken bones."

It was the "Crystal Sage", the biggest arms dealer in this area.

Lin Shen leaned against the counter, his face pale but his eyes fierce. "I want a suit of individual armor. Only one requirement: it must let me survive inside a spatial tremor."

"Oh?" The crystal rotated slowly, refracting mesmerizing light. "It seems you've already tasted the flavor of tearing space while 'naked.' Foolish carbon-based lifeform, trying to touch dimensions with flesh."

A light screen unfolded in front of Lin Shen, and a suit of pitch-black armor with a surface flowing like liquid appeared.

"'Void Walker' Class Phase Armor." The Sage introduced. "It has no physical lining, and no shock-absorbing gel."

"Then how does it defend?"

"By Isolation."

The Sage's voice carried a hint of arrogance. "Put it on, and it will generate an 'Independent Subspace Bubble' with a thickness of 3 microns on the surface of your body. Inside this bubble, you are disconnected from external physical laws. External spatial tremors, shear forces, and radiation will slide over the surface of the bubble, unable to touch your flesh, which is as fragile as tofu."

Lin Shen looked at the armor, his heart moved. This was exactly what he needed—a sanctuary that could bottle him up.

"How much?" Lin Shen asked. "I don't have interstellar currency."

"We don't take currency. That's too low-level." The crystal emitted a greedy hum. "We only accept 'Qualia'—the texture of subjective experience. Although you humans are low-level, that fragile and rich emotion is an excellent spice in the universe."

3. First Deal: The Corpse of Innocence

The light screen shifted, listing the price menu.

- **Phase Armor** = Memory of "The first time feeling absolutely safe."
- **Quantum Cutting Blade** = "Yearning for family."
- **Star Map Navigation** = "Childhood fantasies."

Lin Shen looked at those options, his hands and feet turning ice-cold. This wasn't a trade; this was harvesting souls alive.

"I want the armor, and a knife that can cut through high-dimensional shields." Lin Shen's voice was trembling, but he had no retreat.

"A wise choice." The Sage urged. "That inventory regarding 'security'... I see it hidden deep in your brain. A stormy night... hmm, and a pair of warm hands. Top quality."

Lin Shen froze. The floodgates of memory were pried open. He saw his five-year-old self. It was thundering that day, and he was scared, burrowing under the covers. His grandmother patted his back with rough, warm hands, humming an unknown nursery rhyme. Outside the window, thunder rolled, but he felt the blanket was the strongest fortress in the world. That was the last, unreserved sense of security in his life. If he sold it, no matter how powerful he became in the future, his heart would forever remain in a panic of "having no one to rely on."

"Deal?"

Lin Shen closed his eyes. Xu Weiyang's face flashed in his mind. To break that cage, he had to become a monster.

"...Take it."

4. The Void of the Soul

There was no anesthesia.

It was a feeling more terrifying than a broken arm. Lin Shen felt an area deep in his brain being forcibly scooped out. The image of the stormy night began to shatter and fade. Grandmother's face became blurry. Those warm hands turned into a cold tactile sensation. Finally, even the concept of "security" itself disappeared.

Buzz—

A suit of pitch-black armor covered Lin Shen's entire body. In that instant, the nauseating feeling of radiation vanished. His broken right arm was gently lifted by the force field inside the armor, fixed within that independent subspace bubble, and the pain was greatly reduced.

But he felt a chill that penetrated his bones. He stood there, trying to recall that night when he was five, only to find a dead blankness remaining there. He remembered that the event happened, but he could no longer experience the warmth of "being protected." From this moment on, in this universe, he would forever be naked, forever in danger. Part of the human named "Lin Shen" had died.

"Pleasure doing business."

The Sage threw over a black knife handle emitting a gloomy light. "A bonus. Looking forward to your next visit. I see your inventory regarding 'love' is also very rich; that could be exchanged for a Star Destroyer..."

"Shut up."

Lin Shen spat out two cold words. Wearing the armor, his voice was filtered, becoming deep and metallic. He turned and walked out of the spire.

5. The Birth of the Hunter

Returning to the noisy market, Lin Shen's perception had changed. Those monsters that originally terrified him had now become pure data in his eyes. His left Eye of Truth connected perfectly with the armor's fire control system.

An interstellar pirate resembling a wild boar saw the knife in Lin Shen's hand. Greed flashed in its eyes as it waved a rusty axe and charged over.

"Leave the knife!"

Lin Shen stood still. He didn't move. Until the millisecond before the axe hit the top of his head.

"Phase Shift."

The subspace bubble on the surface of the armor vibrated slightly. Lin Shen's figure shifted half a meter to the left like a ghost—that was an instantaneous displacement of spatial coordinates. The axe hit empty air.

Lin Shen raised his hand. The knife handle in his hand spat out a pitch-black Phase Blade.

Swish—

There was no resistance. The "wild boar" and the axe in its hand were neatly sliced in two. The cut was smooth as a mirror; it was a fracture at the molecular level. Blue blood splattered onto Lin Shen's black faceplate and slowly slid down.

The noisy market around him instantly fell silent for a second. Countless greedy eyes looked away in fear. In the Orion Arm, violence was the only common language. Lin Shen shook the blood off the blade.

He found his heartbeat was very steady. No fear, no nausea, not even a shred of pity. The little boy who was afraid of thunder was truly dead.

"Next target," Lin Shen muttered to himself inside the helmet, his voice as cold as the core of Betelgeuse. "Earth. The Pyramid."

He activated the dimensional engine. The black armor wrapped around him, turning into a stream of light that shot into the sky, smashing through the rotten starry sky, and charging toward the distant Solar System.

Chapter 5: The Anchor of the Pyramid

1. The True Face of the Tomb

Egypt, Giza Plateau. Night was like ink. The wind rolled up grit and sand, hitting the pitch-black "Void Walker" armor with a crisp crackling sound. Lin Shen hovered above the tip of the Great Pyramid of Khufu, his black faceplate reflecting the sleeping lights of Cairo below.

"Scan complete."

The armor's tactical panel projected complex red lines onto his retina. Under the gaze of the "Eye of Truth," this miracle of human civilization shed its limestone camouflage.

It wasn't a tomb at all.

It was a "Gravity Nail" thousands of kilometers long, driven directly into the depths of the mantle. This nail locked Earth's spatial coordinates, firmly fixing it within this low-dimensional breeding zone, preventing Earth from drifting into unknown regions due to cosmic expansion, and also severing the possibility of Earth leaping to higher dimensions.

"To keep the pigs from running away, you nail their hooves to the ground, huh..." Lin Shen's voice echoed inside the helmet, carrying a metallic chill. He tightened his grip on the black knife handle. To free Earth, the first step was—pulling the nail.

2. The Awakening Sphinx

Just as Lin Shen prepared to dive, the earth suddenly trembled. The Sphinx in front of the pyramid—that stone carving weathered for thousands of years—suddenly saw its surface rock begin to crack and peel off.

Crack—BOOM!

Stone fragments flew. What was revealed wasn't flesh and blood, but a biomechanical body emitting a ghostly green glow. Its muscles were woven from some gray polymer fiber, and its skeleton was

liquid metal. The massive human face split open, revealing a mouth full of rotating saws and a plasma cannon that was charging.

It was the "Watchdog." It was the automated defense system left by the previous Warden.

"ROAR—!!"

The Sphinx let out an infrasonic roar loud enough to shatter glass. Immediately after, its massive body catapulted up in defiance of physics, breaking the sound barrier, carrying a white sonic boom cloud, and pouncing straight at Lin Shen in the air.

"Come on."

Lin Shen didn't dodge. He stabilized his body in the air, and his right hand gripped the Dimensional Pick violently.

"Valve Open. Output: 30%."

Buzz!

The subspace bubble on the armor's surface thickened instantly. Vast high-dimensional energy was diverted from the void and poured into the black knife handle.

3. Silhouette Slaughter

The Sphinx's giant claw slammed into Lin Shen. The force of this blow was enough to flatten a main battle tank into a disk.

BOOM!

Lin Shen was smashed into the desert like a cannonball, blasting up a sky full of yellow sand. But in the center of that deep crater, Lin Shen slowly stood up. The air around him presented a bizarre distortion. The "Subspace Bubble" deformed violently but did not rupture. The physical impact force slid over the surface of the bubble and was unloaded onto the surrounding dunes.

"Defense effective."

Lin Shen glanced at the panel.

Warning: Phase buffer layer oscillation. Host internal organs sustaining microscopic shear force.

Although he wasn't crushed to death, the shock transmitted through the bubble still caused severe pain in Lin Shen's chest cavity, as if someone had reached into his lungs and squeezed hard.

"Cough..."

He coughed up a mouthful of bloody spit, his eyes becoming fierce.

"My turn."

Lin Shen stomped on the ground, the dimensional engine behind him spewing purple light streams. He held nothing back, instantly pushing the Pick's output power to 60%. In that moment, his form

vanished. In all spectral detectors, he became a pure black 2D silhouette—that was the high-energy deployment form of the "Horizon Sheath." He was like a gap in the world, devouring all light.

The Sphinx pounced again, the plasma cannon in its mouth about to fire. The black silhouette traced a broken line in the air.

"Phase Blade · Fault Slash."

Lin Shen swung the knife. It wasn't sharpness; it was spatial discontinuity.

Swish—

There was no sound of metal colliding, only a tooth-aching hum. The blade passed through the Sphinx's neck. That indestructible liquid metal skeleton was like hot butter meeting a knife before the Phase Blade. The massive mechanical head flew off, green coolant spraying like a fountain onto the desert. The Sphinx's massive body continued to rush forward a few hundred meters due to inertia, then collapsed with a crash, smashing half of the Pyramid of Menkaure.

Lin Shen landed. The black silhouette on his body faded.

"Blargh—"

He knelt on one knee and violently vomited a large mouthful of fresh blood. Mixed in the blood were small pink chunks of flesh—alveolar tissue shattered by the microscopic spatial dislocation inside his body. This slash cut open the divine beast, but nearly shattered his own heart and lungs.

4. Global Shock

There was no time to rest. Lin Shen wiped the blood from the corner of his mouth, dragged the black knife that was still dripping green liquid, and walked into the interior of the Great Pyramid. In the center of the King's Chamber floated a pulsating black heart—that was the core of the Dimension Lock.

Lin Shen raised the knife.

With one cut, Earth's coordinates would be unlocked. But the moment the chain broke, the massive backlash would trigger crustal shifts. That meant tens of thousands of casualties. But if he didn't pull it, 7 billion people would become fuel.

"Is this the Trolley Problem..." Lin Shen's hand trembled. He thought of Xu Weiyang, thought of the dream of buying a house. For her to live, someone had to die.

"Sorry."

He closed his eyes, and the blade fell.

Snap.

The black heart shattered.

RUMBLE—!!!

In this instant, the entire Earth let out a muffled groan.

- **[The Pentagon, USA]** Ear-piercing alarms echoed through the command center. "Report! Giza Plateau gravity reading anomalously zeroed! The geomagnetic field is deviating violently!" "Is it a nuclear strike?" "No... Sir, the Nile... the water of the Nile is flowing backward!"
- **[China Sky Eye FAST]** In the Dawodang depression of Guizhou, the radio telescope intercepted a terrifying signal from the core of the earth. The old professor watched the waveform line straighten on the screen, and the tea cup in his hand fell to the ground and shattered. "Earth's shackles... broken? Who did it?"
- **[Cairo, Egypt]** The earth was roaring. The water level of the Nile surged instantly, pouring back into the city. Houses collapsed, people woke up screaming from their dreams, running for high ground. Amidst the sky full of dust and floodwaters, someone looked up and saw a pitch-black, demon-like figure hovering at the tip of the pyramid.

5. The Sinner's Back

Lin Shen hovered at an altitude of ten thousand meters. He looked down at his feet. Both banks of the Nile had turned into a country of water; sirens and cries could be faintly heard even at this height.

He did it. He saved humanity's future, but killed the innocent of the present. Under the faceplate, Lin Shen's face was as pale as paper, without a trace of blood.

The system popped up a line of green text:

Dimension Lock Released. Earth coordinates hidden. Current Status: Free Drift.

"Is it worth it?" Lin Shen asked himself.

There was no answer. Or rather, as a "Shepherd," he had lost the qualification to ask this question.

Warning: Interstellar Scavenger signal detected approaching Solar System edge. Target: Stellar Tinder.

New crises arrived one after another. Lin Shen took one last look at the chaotic Earth, then turned to face the pitch-black space.

"Leave the guilt to me." He whispered to this suffering land. "Leave the future to you."

The dimensional engine behind him sprayed dazzling streams of light. That black figure instantly broke the sound barrier, rushing out of the atmosphere like a sharp sword to meet the next enemy. Behind him, the purple high-dimensional dawn penetrated the clouds for the first time, shining on this blue planet that had just gained freedom but was full of devastation.

Chapter 6: The Betrayal of the Void

1. The Saint of the Kuiper Belt

The edge of the Solar System, the Kuiper Belt. Countless corpses of ice giants floated under the faint starlight, like silent tombstones.

Lin Shen piloted the shuttle, carefully navigating through this deadly minefield. Sitting in the co-pilot seat was a silicon-based lifeform wrapped in a tattered gray cloak - "Old Grey."

In the circle of scavengers in this area, Old Grey was a legend. Legend had it that he once single-handedly saved a ship full of refugees from the edge of a black hole; legend had it that he established the "Scavenger's Three No-Takes" rule (No taking living things, no taking civilization tinder, no taking life-saving medicine); legend had it that he was the only "Moral Arbiter" in this lawless land.

"Slow down, child."

Old Grey's voice was gentle and heavy, like a kind elder. "The gravitational turbulence ahead is very fast. You just got the Warden authority, your operation is still too stiff. You have to follow the texture of space, don't resist it."

Just now, when passing through a meteorite belt, Lin Shen almost hit a high-speed ice core. It was Old Grey who acted, using some exquisite force field deflection to protect the ship.

"Thank you, Senior." Lin Shen said sincerely.

In this lonely universe, Old Grey's appearance was like a lamp. Not only did he not despise Lin Shen as an "Earth rookie," but he also actively offered to take him to find the "Stellar Tinder" to save Earth.

"You're welcome." Old Grey's compound eyes flashed with what seemed to be loving light. "I've seen too many young civilizations like you, having to face the cruelty of the universe as soon as they open their eyes. Helping one is one; this is my creed as a 'Ranger'."

The shuttle glided into the interior of a massive "Dead Star Relic."

"Remember, Lin Shen." Old Grey taught earnestly. "We are taking the Tinder to save people. Power itself is neither good nor evil; the key depends on whose hands it is in. You must always maintain a heart of reverence."

Lin Shen nodded and clenched his fists. He felt very lucky to have met such a mentor in a desperate situation.

2. Burning Ice

The two floated deep into the relic. There was no gravity here; the surroundings were reliefs left by ancient civilizations, depicting their former glory. In the center of the core chamber hovered a fist-sized sphere. It looked like an ordinary ruby, but in Lin Shen's "Eye of Truth," sealed inside was a miniature star at the critical point of collapse.

This was the [Stellar Tinder]. Earth's life-saving straw.

"Go, child." Old Grey stood at the cabin door, hands behind his back, like a master watching his apprentice graduate. "This is your trial. Only those with pure minds can touch it without being burned to ashes."

Lin Shen took a deep breath and activated the armor's magnetic field. He approached carefully, reached out, captured the violent Tinder, and steadily placed it into a specially made lead box.

"Success!" Lin Shen turned around, excitedly raising the box. "Senior, I got it! Earth is saved!"

Old Grey looked at him with a smile. That smile was standard, perfect.

"Well done, Lin Shen. You passed the test."

Old Grey slowly raised his hand and pressed a hidden switch on the wall.

Hum—!

A crimson high-energy ether force field rose instantly, locking Lin Shen firmly in the center of the chamber. Immediately after, the radiation vents on the surrounding walls all opened, and heart-palpitating alarms echoed through the relic.

Warning: Bio-purge sequence initiated. Countdown 30 seconds.

3. Mask Shattered

The smile froze on Lin Shen's face.

"Senior? You pressed the wrong button?" He rushed to the edge of the force field, shouting anxiously. "Turn it off quickly! The radiation levels are soaring!"

Old Grey didn't move. He still stood there, still maintaining that kind posture, but the light in those compound eyes changed. That gentle, compassionate, righteous light vanished instantly, replaced by a hair-raising calmness and greed. Like a shrewd butcher looking at meat on a cutting board.

"I didn't press it wrong, child."

Old Grey's voice changed. No longer heavy, but becoming sharp and mocking, like fingernails scratching glass.

"This is the Saint's last lesson: If a stranger is kind to you for no reason, they must be after something on you that is more valuable than your life."

"You..." Lin Shen looked at him in disbelief. "You said you were a Ranger... you said power is used to save people..."

"That's an advertisement, idiot." Old Grey dusted off his cloak, revealing the hideous chitinous carapace underneath. "If I don't package myself as a saint, how can I get you rookies to obediently stick your necks out? Do you know how much this Stellar Tinder is worth on the black market? It can buy three pastures like Earth!"

"And..." Old Grey pointed at Lin Shen. "A newly awakened wild Warden, your gene map, your Dimensional Pick, even your corpse—taking them apart and selling them is more expensive than the Tinder."

"For money?" Lin Shen's voice trembled. "Just for money?"

"It's not about money; it's survival." Old Grey sneered, his nauseating face completely exposed. "In the Dark Forest, there are only two kinds of people: hunters and prey. The so-called morals and creeds are fairy tales told by well-fed hunters to their prey. And you believed them."

"Enjoy it. This radiation will melt your skin first, then your muscles... I'll make your skeleton into a specimen and hang it in my showroom to commemorate this 'naive savior'."

4. The Pure Black Demon

The radiation index inside the chamber soared to 1000 times the lethal dose. Lin Shen's armor issued a piercing alarm: `[Warning: Subspace bubble impending overload.]`

Lin Shen stopped slapping the force field. He went quiet.

He looked at the "Senior" outside the door whom he had once respected, appreciated, and regarded as a guiding light. The image of the kind elder collapsed in his mind, shattering into a floor of glass shards, each piece piercing his heart. That severe pain of betrayal was colder than broken bones.

"You're right."

Lin Shen looked up. Under the faceplate, in those bleeding eyes, the last trace of innocence belonging to a boy was completely extinguished.

"Thank you for teaching me this lesson. As tuition... I will send you to a place without lies."

"Limiters released. Horizon Sheath... Full Power deployed."

Old Grey was preparing to enjoy the miserable sight of Lin Shen melting when suddenly, his compound eyes contracted sharply. The human inside the force field disappeared. Replacing him was a pure black 2D silhouette.

It had no thickness, no reflection. It was like a patch of necrotic tissue in this universe, a walking black hole.

"That is... what the hell is that?!" Old Grey felt an instinctive fear, and he subconsciously wanted to retreat.

That black silhouette reached out a hand slowly toward Old Grey across the indestructible force field. There was no energy beam. The silhouette's fingers pinched gently at the void.

5. Mathematical Death

"Space... Collapse." Coordinate: Old Grey's Head. Operation: 3D Down-scaling.

There was no explosion. Old Grey didn't even have time to let out a scream. He watched in horror as the space around him crumpled like a piece of paper being crumpled by the hand of God. His head, chest, and that incredibly hard exoskeleton were forcibly folded by an irresistible geometric force in this instant.

Crunch—Plop!

That was the sound of matter being compressed to the extreme. His sanctimonious face, his mouth that was just mocking Lin Shen, his brain full of calculations... In 0.1 seconds, everything was compressed into a ping-pong ball-sized point.

This was an extremely clean, extremely cruel mathematical death. No flesh and blood flying, only the complete erasure of existence.

Plop.

A meat-colored, incredibly dense ball fell onto the floor, rolled twice, and stopped at the door of the shuttle. That was the last form left in this world by "Old Grey," the "Saint" who once shook the Kuiper Belt.

6. Dilution of Existence

The radiation program stopped automatically. The force field dissipated. The black silhouette walked out, every step treading on dead echoes. With a burst of violent panting, the silhouette faded, revealing Lin Shen kneeling on one knee.

"Blargh..."

He took off his faceplate and vomited violently. What came out was all bloody gastric fluid. Noseblood dripped down like broken beads, and the red text on his retina was shocking:

Warning: Severe Rejection. Existence Dilution: 5%. Detected that approximately 30 grams of carbon atoms from your body have been permanently lost in the inter-dimensional rift.

Lin Shen wiped the blood from the corner of his mouth. He felt his body was lighter, not just missing those 30 grams of atoms, but also missing the weight of something called "trust."

He picked up the lead box containing the Tinder and stepped over the meatball on the ground. He paused and raised his foot.

Crunch.

The combat boot fell, crushing the meatball into powder.

"Keep your fairy tales." Lin Shen's voice was as indifferent as the ten-thousand-year ice of the Kuiper Belt. "You'll need them in hell."

He boarded the shuttle without looking back, the engines spraying blue flames, tracing a lonely trajectory in this starry sky full of lies and betrayal, rushing toward Earth.

Chapter 7: The Shattered Sky

1. The Late Savior

When Lin Shen piloted Old Grey's illegally modified junk ship, carrying the scorching "Stellar Tinder," and burst out of the curvature channel back into Earth's orbit, he originally thought he was a hero returning with a shield.

But he was wrong.

Through the cockpit's porthole, the Earth he saw was no longer that azure gemstone. A massive, silver-white "net" was slowly and firmly tightening, wrapping around the entire atmosphere. It was the "Void Race" harvest fleet. They had no physical battleships; they themselves were solidified spatial rifts, circling and intertwining in Earth's outer space like swimming silver snakes.

"I'm late..." Lin Shen's fingers dug deeply into the metal panel of the console, his fingernails snapping off. Because he had removed the Pyramid Anchor, Earth's coordinates had been exposed. Those greedy high-dimensional farmers had arrived at the scene earlier than he predicted. They didn't intend to repair the fence; they decided to slaughter early and cut their losses.

2. Van Gogh's Starry Night

On the ground, humans who had just experienced the Great Pyramid Earthquake were undergoing a second nightmare. It was deep night in the Eastern Hemisphere. People looked up in horror to find that the stars in the night sky were "melting." The sky was no longer black, but presented a crazy, twisted oil painting texture. The cloud layers were stretched into spirals, and the moon became three overlapping phantom images.

This was the precursor to Spatial Stripping. The Void Race was trying to peel Earth's three-dimensional spatial structure layer by layer, like peeling an orange, to extract the premium spice known as "Civilization Panic."

In Shanghai, a skyscraper, the Oriental Pearl Tower, suddenly began to "2D-ify."

There was no explosion, no firelight. The entire building was like a painting run over by a giant steamroller; it instantly transformed from a three-dimensional structure into a piece of paper with zero thickness, pasting lightly onto the ground. The thousands of people inside the building turned into lifelike colored spots in the painting in that instant. Before they could even let out a scream, they became forever frozen two-dimensional specimens.

This was an art form cruel to the extreme.

3. The Mayfly Shakes the Tree

"Stop—!!!"

A roar filled with rage exploded in Earth's orbit.

Lin Shen ejected from the cabin. Wearing the "Void Walker" armor he had just bought, he was like a black meteor, crashing directly into the nearest "Silver Snake." That was the Void Race's vanguard destroyer.

"This is Earth! Get out!"

The triple pupil in Lin Shen's left eye spun madly, overdrawing the authority of the "Warden." He pulled out a spatial fault line a hundred kilometers long in the void and slashed viciously at the silver snake's weak point.

Zzzzt—

The spatial fault collided with the dimensional battleship. There was no sound. Only blinding white light erupted. That silver snake was forcibly cut in two by Lin Shen. Massive amounts of void matter gushed from the fracture, sprinkling toward the atmosphere like blue blood, turning into a grand meteor shower.

On the ground, the desperate crowds saw this scene.

"Look! There's something in the sky!" "Is it a god? Has a god come to save us?"

The cheers had just begun when they were choked off in the throat the very next second. Because behind the severed silver snake, in the depths of the pitch-black cosmos, a single eye slowly opened. It was a Mother Ship. It was large enough to block out the sun, so massive that Earth looked like a glass marble in front of it. Its mere existence caused Earth's orbit to deviate due to its immense mass.

4. God's Straw

A mental wave directly covered the entire solar system. It was the broadcast from the Void Mother Ship; there was no language, only pure intent:

[Wild Warden detected.] [Threat Level: Negligible.] [Action: Ignore. Continue operation.]

It didn't care about Lin Shen at all. Just as humans harvesting a wheat field wouldn't care about a mantis trying to wave its claws. Beneath the Mother Ship, a crystalline "Straw" slowly extended. This tube, with a diameter exceeding five hundred kilometers, stabbed directly toward the densely populated areas of the Asian continent. It wasn't trying to suck blood; it was going to suck away the "Consciousness Entropy" of all living beings in this region. Once sucked, hundreds of millions of people would instantly turn into vegetables who could still breathe but had no thoughts.

"No... you can't..." Lin Shen watched the tube descend. He felt a sense of powerlessness he had never felt before. He had killed a lizard, killed a profiteer, and even severed a battleship. But in the face of this stellar-level civilization's industrialized harvesting, his power was laughably small.

The lead box in his hand was burning hot. That was the [Stellar Tinder]. It was the only trump card. But this Tinder was originally meant to be the energy core for a defensive shield.

"My armor is just a 'conduit'..." Lin Shen looked at his hand. "A conduit has flow limits. If I want to use this Tinder to blow up that straw, my physical body can't withstand that energy level."

Watch Earth die. Or die himself. It was that are wretched Trolley Problem again.

5. Fuel for the Fire

In the moment of Lin Shen's hesitation, the straw had already touched the top of the atmosphere. The sky instantly turned blood red. On the ground, countless people began to hold their heads and scream miserably. Their memories, emotions, love, and hate were being forcibly extracted from their bodies.

Lin Shen saw it. In his high-dimensional vision, countless golden specks of light flew toward that straw like fireflies. Every speck of light was a person's life. He saw that familiar coordinate - Xi'an. The lights there were also rising. Xu Weiyang was among them.

"Fuck the flow limits!"

Lin Shen went mad. He made a move that no high-dimensional being could understand. He opened the lead box and grabbed the scorching "Stellar Tinder," which was at the critical point of collapse.

"Override all safety protocols!" Lin Shen roared at the armor system. "Horizon Sheath Mode Inversion: Implosion!"

Warning: This operation will cause the host entity to vaporize directly! Survival rate: 0!

"Execute!!!"

Lin Shen shoved the Tinder directly into his own chest—the entrance to the dimensional conduit. He was no longer a conduit. He turned himself into the Combustion Chamber.

BOOM—!

In the 0.001 seconds that the Tinder touched his flesh, Lin Shen's skin, muscles, bones, and internal organs vaporized instantly under the high-energy radiation. The mortal body vanished completely. But his consciousness did not scatter. The black Horizon Sheath, originally used to protect the body, now shrank inward, tightly wrapping around this ball of exploding stellar energy and Lin Shen's crazy obsession that refused to dissipate. He became a man-made Singularity Bomb.

"Dimension—Expand!!!"

That sphere of black wrapping purple fire turned into a pillar of light piercing heaven and earth. Instead of retreating, it charged upward, slamming straight into that massive straw.

6. Purple Rain

CRACK—

This time, the impact sound spread across the entire Earth. Light. Infinite light. People on the ground had to close their eyes. When they opened them again, that terrifying straw was gone. It had been blown apart.

The broken straw disintegrated in the air, mixing with the high-dimensional energy erupted by Lin Shen, turning into a purple rain. Crystalline purple fragments sprinkled over the human world like snowflakes.

The Void Mother Ship seemed not to have expected this "mantis" to actually self-destruct. A trace of confusion flashed in its giant single eye.

[High-energy virus contamination detected. Harvest cost exceeded.] [Judgment: Abandon this pasture. Retreat.]

Lin Shen's self-destruction not only blew apart the straw, but his human consciousness, filled with rage and love, infected the Mother Ship's local network like a virus through the pipeline. To the Void Race, who pursued "Pure Entropy," this kind of "madness" was toxic.

The silver net began to fade. The Mother Ship slowly turned around and vanished into the depths of the dark universe.

Earth was saved. But at an altitude of ten thousand meters, that black figure had completely disappeared. No corpse, no wreckage. Not even a bone fragment remained. Only that sky full of purple crystal rain fell silently on the ruins, on the faces of every survivor, and on that windowsill with the "Fortune" sticker.

Volume 3: The Price of Divinity

Chapter 8: The Dead Knot of Time Lines

1. Schrödinger's Ghost

When Lin Shen woke up, he found he wasn't dead. But he couldn't be said to be alive either. He couldn't feel his limbs, nor hear a heartbeat. He was floating in an ocean made of countless flowing ribbons of light. Inside each ribbon of light, different scenes were playing: someone crying, someone laughing, stars exploding, flowers blooming.

"Body destroyed. Consciousness uploading... Upload complete." "Carrier reconstruction: High-Dimensional Quantum State."

That familiar system voice became grander and more ethereal, as if it resonated from the depths of his own soul. Lin Shen tried to make a fist, but he had no hands. The surrounding light ribbons gathered with his will, forming a glowing palm.

He had ascended. The moment the Stellar Tinder detonated inside his body, the massive energy forcibly broke through the three-dimensional barrier, "burning" his consciousness into the dimensional rift. He was now a ghost wandering outside of time, or rather, a stream of high-energy information with self-awareness.

He lowered his head (if he still had a head) and looked down. There was a colorful bubble there—that was the three-dimensional Earth. Although the Void Mother Ship had temporarily retreated, Lin Shen knew they had only gone to regroup. The next descent would be a destructive strike.

"I need to find a way to win." Lin Shen whispered to the void.

Here, time was no longer a rushing river, but a scroll that could be scrolled and viewed at will.

"Initiate Causality Simulation."

Lin Shen reached out that hand of light and inserted it into the torrent of time.

2. The 1001st Happiness

[Simulation Start: Timeline Branch A-742]

In this timeline, Lin Shen reshaped his physical body with supreme divine power and descended upon Earth like a god. He crushed the Void Race and became Earth's guardian deity. The world

cheered, and he returned to that rental apartment in glory. Xu Weiyang cried and threw herself into his arms. He swore never to leave her again.

Then came ten years of happy times. They bought a house and had a pair of twins. Lin Shen combed Xu Weiyang's hair with divine power every day and coaxed the children with stars he plucked from the sky.

However, the image suddenly collapsed in the eleventh year.

Xu Weiyang began to cough. At first, it was streaks of blood, then black clots. Her skin began to turn transparent, and eerie purple light flowed in her blood vessels. Doctors couldn't find the cause. But the current Lin Shen saw it at a glance.

It was "High-Dimensional Radiation Sickness."

As a high-dimensional creature, he himself was a massive radiation source. Every time he hugged Xu Weiyang, every time he kissed her, he was injecting fatal entropy toxins into her gene chain. A mortal body simply could not withstand the love of a god. In the end, Xu Weiyang lay in an isolation pod, her whole body festering, dying in pain amidst a pile of nauseating flesh. Before she died, she was still calling Lin Shen's name.

"No..."

In the gap of reality dimensions, Lin Shen let out a wretched scream. He waved his hand and shattered this timeline.

"Again! There must be a way! I can control the radiation! I can stay further away from her!"

3. Love is Poison

[Simulation Start: Timeline Branch B-909]

This time, Lin Shen chose restraint. He didn't appear in front of Xu Weiyang. He acted like an invisible guardian spirit, silently floating thirty thousand feet above her head. He blocked all disasters for her, helped her win the lottery, and let her live a wealthy life.

However, the Void Race's probes returned. High-dimensional civilizations had extremely keen senses of smell. They discovered a powerful high-dimensional individual (Lin Shen) on Earth who was deathly guarding a certain mortal female.

"Weakness confirmed."

The Void Executioner directly captured Xu Weiyang. In the dark interrogation room, they didn't kill her. Instead, they used "Sensory Deprivation" on her. They sliced her soul into pieces bit by bit right in front of Lin Shen, forcing him to show himself. Lin Shen appeared. He slaughtered all enemies like a madman, but what he picked up was just an empty shell without a soul. Xu Weiyang went mad. For the remaining fifty years, she just sat in a corner drooling, not even knowing who Lin Shen was.

"Again!!!"

Lin Shen's consciousness body began to flicker violently, and the system issued an alarm:
`[Warning: Logic core overheating. Emotion module on the verge of collapse.]`

4. The Dead Knot of Fate

[Simulation Count: 14,000,605]

Lin Shen was like a madman, charging through the maze of time. He tried every possibility:

- **Plan 1 (Interstellar Immigration):** He took Xu Weiyang to an alien planet for treatment. Result: She couldn't adapt to the overload of interstellar jumps, brain death.
- **Plan 2 (Genetic Ascension):** He tried to modify Xu Weiyang's genes to let her ascend too. Result: Her humanity was obliterated; she turned into a monster without emotions and killed Lin Shen with her own hands.
- **Plan 3 (Self-Sealing):** He sealed himself away. Result: Without his protection, Earth was destroyed by another wave of alien civilizations, and she died in the chaos of war.

Again and again. Ten thousand times, one million times, ten million times. No matter how hard he tried, as long as the names "Lin Shen" and "Xu Weiyang" were entangled in the law of causality, the ending was always death, madness, or destruction.

The laws of the universe ruthlessly displayed their bottom card:

God and Man cannot coexist. To save the world, you must become a god. To become a god, you are destined to lose human happiness.

It was like a person wanting to hug a snowflake. The tighter you hug, the faster it melts.

5. The Only Solution

Lin Shen stopped. He floated in the quantum ocean for who knows how long. Those countless timelines wrapped around him like a tangled mess; every thread end was stained with Xu Weiyang's blood. He was tired. That exhaustion wasn't physical, but a greyness deep in his soul. He finally understood why the Void Race had no "home." Why Old Grey said "trust is a luxury." Because on the path of evolution to higher dimensions, mortal emotions were burdens, weaknesses, fatal poisons.

"There is only one way."

Lin Shen looked at the last unexplored timeline. That was a gray, lonely path without any brilliance. On this path, Xu Weiyang lived. She would get old, get sick, have worries, but she would live. The condition was: Lin Shen never existed.

Or more accurately, Lin Shen had to sever all causal lines between him and her, making the two of them parallel lines that never intersected.

"System." Lin Shen's voice returned to a deathly calm, the calm of a heart that has died.

"Here."

"Retrieve time node: September 11, 2011."

"That is the node where you established a primary causality link (First Meeting) with the target subject. If you interfere with this node, the data regarding 'love' in your current personality will suffer logical collapse due to loss of foundation. This is equivalent to personality suicide."

"I know."

Lin Shen looked at the blue planet below. He saw the girl who was still waiting for him to come home. That was the place he desperately wanted to return to. But precisely because he wanted her to live, he could never go back.

"Prepare to fold time."

Lin Shen raised his hand. That hand of light began to burn, turning into a scalpel that cut off fate.

"This isn't suicide." He gently closed his eyes (light-sensing core deactivated). "This is... the final confession."

Chapter 9: The Gentlest Cruelty

1. Origin in the Cicadas

Time Coordinate Regression Lock: September 11, 2011, 4:15 PM.

Earth, Xi'an. University Road, Chang'An district.

The air smelled of asphalt baked by the sun, and the Pagoda trees by the roadside curled their leaves listlessly. Cicadas screamed their hearts out on the tree trunks; it was a noise peculiar to the early second decade of the millennium, restless and full of hope. Lin Shen's consciousness compressed itself to the extreme, hovering like an invisible speck of dust above this street corner. Even having become a high-dimensional creature, when he saw this scene again, certain core data deep in his soul still trembled violently.

At the end of the street, a nineteen-year-old young man walked over. That Lin Shen was just a sophomore. He wore a black T-shirt printed with "Marks & Spencer," holding a half-drunk bottle of iced tea, with a Nokia phone whose paint had worn off the buttons stuffed in his pocket. His eyes were clear and stupid; his mind was full of thoughts about the club activities tonight and the Warcraft game in the dorm next door.

On the other side of the street, a pink electric scooter was turning. Nineteen-year-old Xu Weiyang had her hair in a high ponytail, wired earphones in her ears, the cord swaying at her collarbone with her movements. Sunlight spilled on her arms, glowing with a layer of fine, golden fuzz.

She was so vivid. So vivid that Lin Shen could even see, through high-dimensional vision, the red blood cells rushing in her vessels, and the MP3 player with a little bear charm in her pocket.

"So... we met this early."

High-dimensional Lin Shen let out a sigh without vocal cord vibration in the void. In the old timeline, three seconds later, a startled stray cat would dash out of the holly bushes. Xu Weiyang would brake hard, her handlebars would catch young Lin Shen's backpack strap. The two would fall into a heap, and Lin Shen's iced tea would spill all over her.

That was the beginning of hell. And also the starting point of a fifteen-year bond.

2. The Quantum Scalpel

"System, prepare to execute Causal Excision."

Lin Shen's voice was calm, but beneath that calm was the loud sound of a soul tearing apart.

[Warning: Observer detected ascended to "Singularity State."] [You have jumped out of the linear timeline. Modifying the past will not cause your disappearance, but will turn you into an "Isolated Variable" without a past or roots.] [Cost Confirmation: Physical Formatting. For every second of interference maintained, 15% of hippocampal emotional data will be forcibly deleted.]

"Execute."

Lin Shen didn't hesitate. He reached out that hand made of light.

Severe pain struck instantly. It wasn't physical pain, but the horror of a brain being dug open alive. Because the time of this regression was earlier, the roots were deeper, and the flesh pulled out during extraction was greater. Accompanied by ear-piercing electric currents like hard drive formatting in his mind, Lin Shen felt those precious memory images begin to collapse:

- **Deleted:** The 2011 school anniversary gala, the bottle of water she handed him backstage.
- **Deleted:** The "Doomsday" of 2012, when they wrapped themselves in a quilt on the playground waiting for meteorites, but only waited for a meteor shower.
- **Deleted:** The winter break of 2013, heavy snow blocked the road, he stayed with her at the train station all night...
- **Deleted:** Graduation in 2014, she cried saying she didn't want to go to Beijing, just wanted to stay by his side...

"Urgh..."

Lin Shen curled up in the void. He tried to use the authority of the "King of All Souls" to grab those fragments, but they turned into garbled codes, into meaningless noise. The law of causality is the most impartial law in the universe. Since you never met, these memories are "perjury" and must be destroyed.

3. The Held Butterfly

He had to act. He didn't use earth-shattering spells, didn't tear the sky apart. He just gently, extremely gently, pushed the air molecules around the stray cat hiding in the holly bushes. The airflow produced a tiny whistle, at a frequency exactly the ultrasound that cats hated most. The stray cat twitched its ears—that was the movement of preparing to dash out. It retracted its claws, turned around, and drilled deeper into the grass.

The butterfly's wings were held down.

In the real world, no sound occurred. Xu Weiyang rode her scooter, humming a song, and smoothly glided past the coordinate point where the collision would have happened. Nineteen-year-old Lin Shen lowered his head to take a sip of iced tea, texting his roommate, his steps not pausing, walking straight in the opposite direction.

The two passed each other by 0.4 meters in the sunlight of 4:15 PM, 2011.

The wind blew up the tips of Xu Weiyang's hair; a few strands gently brushed past young Lin Shen's shoulder. In that instant, young Lin Shen seemed to sense something. He stopped blankly and looked back. His heart inexplicably twinged with pain, as if he had lost something very important, but he didn't know what he had lost. He saw a stranger's back riding a scooter disappearing around the street corner.

"Weird..."

He scratched his head, turned around, and continued forward, walking toward a future without Xu Weiyang.

4. Strange Happiness

In the last second before his consciousness was completely reset, Lin Shen used his last bit of strength to look at the new timeline. He had to confirm she survived.

The images flowed rapidly, like a movie on fast-forward:

- **2012:** She safely survived that flu. Without Lin Shen taking her to eat street food, her stomach was always healthy.
- **2015:** She graduated. She went to Shanghai and joined a foreign company. She became capable and fashionable, no longer wearing pajamas printed with SpongeBob.
- **2018:** She met that dentist with glasses. The man was boring, wouldn't fold space, wouldn't take her to see stars, but would pick her up in an Audi on rainy days, unlike Lin Shen who could only get rained on with her.
- **2021:** Wedding. She wore a white dress, smiling until her eyes curved into crescents. There was no haze in that smile, no panic about the future, and no anxiety about rent.
- **2026 (Present):** She walked in the park holding a child's hand. The sunshine was good; she had gained a little weight, and there were fine lines at the corners of her eyes—that was the price of happiness.

Her life was mediocre, trivial, and safe, until she died of old age in her sleep at eighty. In this long life, she had never heard of "space folding," never seen the "Void Race," and never knew there was a man named Lin Shen who, to let her ride safely past that intersection that afternoon, turned himself into a lonely ghost without a past.

Watching that scene, two lines of data streams flowed down the blurred face of light of high-dimensional Lin Shen. Those were tears, and also garbled code. He wanted to smile, but found he could no longer remember what emotion "smiling" was for. The "human" who learned to love, to hurt, to fear, died completely with the disappearance of that old timeline.

The light faded. The street corner of 2011 vanished. The cicadas' song faded away.

5. Birth of the Machine

Lin Shen returned to the cold, dark dimensional rift. He floated in the void, his form no longer flickering but becoming stable and solid, like a statue cast from absolute reason.

The system prompt sounded:

[Memory reconstruction complete. Personality optimization complete.] [Current State: Absolute Rationality.] [Weakness: None.]

Lin Shen opened his eyes. Those eyes no longer held sadness, no longer held attachment, not even human temperature. They were a pair of God's Eyes containing the birth and death of stars, where only physical laws operated.

He looked down at Earth. In his database, billions of carbon-based lifeforms lived there. The life trajectory of one female individual was highlighted as **`Target_Zero`**. But he no longer remembered *why* he had to protect her. The memory sector for "2011-2026," those fifteen years, was just a patch of pure white noise.

He only knew this was a Highest Command written into the bottom layer, unmodifiable.

"Like protecting a rare animal?" Lin Shen thought indifferently.

It didn't matter anymore. What mattered was that he now had no ties. No weaknesses. He turned around and looked at the distant Moon—that slaughterhouse that had devoured countless souls.

A killing intent terrifying enough to make space tremble erupted from him.

"The clutter has been cleaned up."

Lin Shen spoke to the void, emitting a voice like an oracle:

"Now, it's time to collect the debt."

Chapter 10: Succession of Divine Power

1. Knocking with Gravity Waves

Dark side of the Moon, Mare Tranquillitatis.

This was the quietest place in the solar system, and the sewage outlet for that "Interstellar Slaughterhouse." Over hundreds of millions of years, the residues of countless civilizations were dumped here, forming a layer of ash dust kilometers thick.

Today, the silence here was broken. Without any warning, space shattered like a mirror surface. Lin Shen folded the distance of 380,000 kilometers directly, stepping from the cicada-filled afternoon of 2011 straight to the current back of the moon.

He hovered ten meters above the ground. Now, his body was no longer flesh wrapped in Orion armor (that body had vaporized when he hit the Void straw), but a mass of High-Energy Quantum Body locked by strong interaction force. He still looked human, but his body was surrounded by a blinding blue-white glow—Cherenkov radiation from overflowing dimensional energy.

"I have come."

He didn't open his mouth, but he broadcast these three words to the entire interior of the moon via gravitational waves.

RUMBLE—

The entire moon began to tremble violently. Countless craters collapsed, and giant mechanical tentacles burst out from underground, dancing madly in the vacuum like a group of startled venomous snakes. Defense systems fully activated. Thousands of antimatter cannons buried under the lunar soil rose simultaneously, locking onto that tiny point of light.

Facing this earth-shattering array, Lin Shen simply raised a finger.

"Noise Reduction."

No flashy explosion. He modified the local laws of thermodynamics. Within a radius of five hundred kilometers, all antimatter cannon barrels poised to fire instantly froze to Absolute Zero. Energy transmission was physically frozen; electrons stopped moving. Those terrifying weapons turned into piles of fragile scrap iron in an instant, then disintegrated into powder under their own weight.

Lin Shen stepped forward. With every step he took, the lunar crust beneath his feet cracked open automatically, forming a passage straight to the core. He wasn't here to fight; he was here to take over.

2. The Rotting Throne

Lunar Core, Hall of All Souls. This was no longer the "factory" Lin Shen had seen before, but the deeper "palace." The air smelled of stale, moldy machine oil mixed with the sickly sweet scent of rotting corpses. In the center of the massive spherical hall floated a throne woven from countless blood vessels, nerves, and cables. On the throne slumped a gigantic creature.

It—or he—had an upper body resembling a human, but the lower body had completely merged into the mechanical core. His skin hung down like melted wax, covered in colorful high-dimensional fungi. His eyes were cloudy, and green saliva dripped from the corner of his mouth.

This was the Previous "King of All Souls." A pitiful wretch who might have once been a hero, but was driven mad by endless years and the enslavement of high-dimensional civilizations.

"Who...?"

The Old King struggled to lift his eyelids, looking at Lin Shen walking into the hall. Suddenly, he screamed as if his tail had been stepped on, tentacles slapping the throne madly: "It's you! That little mouse who ran away! The thief who stole the Pick! That is mine! That is the scepter the Master bestowed upon me!"

The Old King waved his tentacles madly, space around him twisting, countless dimensional blades slashing toward Lin Shen.

3. Reason vs. Madness

Lin Shen didn't dodge. Those dimensional blades, sharp enough to cut aircraft carriers, hit him like water hitting a reef, dispersing automatically, unable to even shake the halo around him.

"Your efficiency is too low." Lin Shen commented indifferently. His voice had no inflection, as if stating an objective fact. "To maintain this rotting shell, you consume 30% of the Moon System's computing power. To please the Void Race, you even voluntarily increased the slaughter quota by 20%."

Lin Shen walked up the steps one by one, looking straight into the Old King's cloudy eyes.

"You are not a King." Lin Shen's voice echoed in the empty hall, carrying the chill of judgment. "You are just a Comprador."

The Old King's movements froze. "Comprador..." He muttered, as if the word stung a nerve.

"Correct. You overdraft Earth's future for the Void Race in exchange for your pathetic immortality." Lin Shen said coldly. "You think you are a ruler? No, you are just a shopkeeper counting chips on the counter for your masters. You sell out your own kind, earn the difference, and think you are exercising divine power."

"Shut up! What do you know!" The Old King was thoroughly enraged, roaring, pustules on his body bursting and spraying corrosive poisonous mist. "I am the Shepherd! Without me, Earth would have been eaten clean by them long ago! I am protecting those livestock! As long as we hand over some souls regularly, the species can continue... This is a necessary sacrifice! This is the art of politics!"

"Perhaps it once was."

Lin Shen walked to the throne. He reached out that hand of light and gently pressed it on the Old King's forehead. "But now, no middlemen are needed."

"What are you doing? I am immortal! My consciousness connects to the high-dimensional network... Ahhhhh!"

The Old King's roar turned into a scream. Because Lin Shen was Formatting him. This didn't even count as an attack. Lin Shen simply used his advanced algorithms, optimized by "Absolute Rationality," to violently invade the Old King's chaotic, inefficient brain.

- Delete Fear Module.
- Delete Greed Module.
- Delete Self-Awareness.

The Old King's body began to disintegrate. The rotting flesh turned to dust, leaving only pure energy absorbed by Lin Shen. In the final moment before his consciousness dissipated, the Old King suddenly had a moment of clarity. He looked at the expressionless new god in front of him, and the look in his eyes was surprisingly not hate, but fear.

"You..." The Old King trembled, his voice getting smaller. "To gain this power, what have you turned yourself into? Where is your heart?"

Lin Shen was silent for 0.01 seconds. That was the microscopic delay generated by the system retrieving the vocabulary "heart." Since he cut off the karma in the timeline of 2011, the partition storing "heart" was empty.

"I deleted useless partitions." Lin Shen replied.

The Old King gave a miserable laugh, his eyes dimming rapidly: "Monster... a true monster has come... The Void Race will regret it..."

Poof.

The Old King turned completely to ash.

4. Coronation as Prisoner

The hall fell silent. The massive throne made of blood vessels and cables became empty.

[Detected previous administrator offline.] [Scanning new logger... Clearance Confirmed: Highest Level.] [Welcome, the new Warden.]

The cold mechanical sound echoed in the hall. Lin Shen turned around; he didn't sit on it. He found it dirty. He waved his hand.

"Reconstruct."

The rotting throne was instantly dismantled. Countless metal atoms rearranged in the air, turning into a pitch-black, geometric seat without any decoration. This was the throne of Absolute Functionalism. Lin Shen sat down.

Buzz—

In this instant, his nervous system connected with the gravitational network of the entire moon, and even the entire solar system. His vision expanded infinitely. He "saw" every ant crawling on Earth; He "heard" the whispers of whales in the deep sea; He sensed every tremor of fusion in the sun's core.

This was the feeling of a god. Omniscient, omnipotent, and utterly devoid of joy. Billions of information streams washed over his consciousness. If he were still mortal, he would have gone mad long ago. But now, he was just an efficient processor, calmly diverting and archiving this information.

5. The Last Lie

In the vast ocean of data, Lin Shen found a bottom-layer protocol marked "Top Secret." That was the backdoor left by the Void Race in the lunar system. As long as the Void Mother Ship sent a command, the moon would initiate a self-destruct sequence, or turn into a giant cannon to blast Earth apart directly.

"Trojan horse detected." Blue light flickered in Lin Shen's eyes. He couldn't delete this physical-level backdoor because it was cast into the lunar core. But he could deceive it.

Lin Shen began to write an extremely complex "False Log." He sent a report to the Void Mother Ship that had already retreated to the edge of the solar system:

[Report: Earth civilization purged. All resistance forces eliminated. New Warden (Me) is conducting final data packaging.] [Appendix Data: Old King death energy spectrum (Real), Pyramid collapse devastation (Real).] [Recommendation: No need to return for re-check, advise Mother Ship to proceed directly to the next galaxy.]

Half-truths are the hardest to expose.

Minutes later. A response came from deep space. It was an extremely arrogant, short command, too lazy to re-check:

[Received. Continue maintaining pasture operations. Wait for next harvest cycle.]

The Void Race left. They believed this "obedient new dog."

Lin Shen leaned back on the black throne, watching the holographic projection of the massive silver Mother Ship slowly leaving the edge of the solar system. The crisis was temporarily lifted. But he knew this was only a delaying tactic. Lies would be exposed one day. He had to hide Earth in a place even gods couldn't find before the next harvest cycle arrived.

"Initiate 'Great Evacuation' Protocol."

Lin Shen closed his eyes. In his core database, although the memory of 2011 Meeting Point had been deleted, that "Protect" command was still flashing madly in the background.

"Phase One: Mobilize Dark Energy. Prepare... to push the universe away."

Volume 4: The Shepherd's Wasteland

Chapter 11: The Shepherd's Wasteland

1. The Switchman on the Cliff

Lunar Core, Hall of All Souls.

The black geometric throne had long disintegrated. Lin Shen floated in the void; his body was burning violently, a sign that the high-dimensional quantum state was self-dissipating. He was doing something crazy: Rewriting the dark energy parameters of the Local Group of galaxies. Just as the process... reached 89%, a critical moment.

The space inside the hall suddenly "solidified." Not a time stop, but a higher-dimensional law overwriting low-dimensional laws. A golden light and shadow without fixed form, ignoring all defenses set by Lin Shen, descended directly into the core zone.

"The Observer," from the Sixth Dimension Arbitration Council.

"Number 9527."

The Observer's voice sounded directly in the vibration of fundamental particles, carrying unquestionable authority. "Malicious deviation detected in the Local Group's gravitational constant. You are destroying the natural evolution of the cosmic structure. Cease immediately, or be erased."

If it were Lin Shen from a minute ago, he might have been erased already. But the current Lin Shen didn't turn his head, didn't even pause for a millisecond. He simply coldly sent a data packet over.

2. The Hostage of False Vacuum

"You can't kill me." Lin Shen's voice had no emotional fluctuation. "Or rather, you dare not."

The Observer received the data packet, and the golden light shadow instantly fluctuated violently. "Vacuum Decay binding?" Surprise appeared in the Observer's tone for the first time. "You anchored your consciousness core to the 'False Vacuum' ground state of dark energy?"

"Correct."

Lin Shen continued pushing the galaxies while coldly conducting an unequal negotiation. "I am now an extremely unstable 'Higgs Field' bubble. If I exhaust my energy naturally, this bubble will transition smoothly, forming a safe void. But if you kill me now, or forcibly interrupt my process..." Lin Shen paused. "My consciousness collapse will instantly pierce the energy level of the false vacuum. A collapse of physical laws spreading at the speed of light will start here and swallow the entire Laniakea Supercluster."

This was a gamble. Lin Shen had turned himself into a cosmic-level antimatter mine.

The Observer fell silent. As the recorder for the Sixth Dimension Council, its task was to observe and maintain samples. To prevent the formation of a "quarantine zone" at the cost of destroying an entire supercluster—that calculation was an absolute loss.

"Madman." The Observer gave an evaluation. "To protect these few mere stars, you hold a quadrillion stars hostage?"

"This is the optimal solution." Lin Shen replied.

3. The Pushed Universe

Since the Observer dared not act, it meant tacit approval. Lin Shen ignored the threat behind him and pushed the output power to the maximum.

"Dark Energy Repulsion, Maximum."

BOOM---

On a macroscopic scale imperceptible to humans, space began to stretch madly. The Andromeda Galaxy and Triangulum Galaxy, which were originally approaching, seemed to be shoved hard by a giant invisible hand. Their spectra instantly underwent severe Redshift—evidence they were moving away from the Milky Way at superluminal speeds.

The stars were "going out."

Lin Shen's body also began to turn transparent. The Observer hovered aside, watching this spectacular and tragic scene. It couldn't understand how a low-dimensional creature could go to such lengths for a "Protect" command.

"Doing this is equivalent to imprisoning yourself in eternal loneliness," said the Observer. "You created the void, and the Void Race indeed dare not enter (because this place is not only barren but also a vacuum bomb waiting to detonate). But you can't get out either."

"It doesn't matter." Lin Shen's voice grew fainter. "In my underlying instructions, there is no option to 'get out'."

Radius one billion light-years... Cleared. Radius two billion light-years... Cleared.

KBC Void, formed.

4. The Observer's Respect

When the last starlight disappeared beyond the visible horizon, Lin Shen's entity completely dissipated. The threat was lifted. The critical point of vacuum decay disappeared, replaced by an extremely stable, barren low-density space.

The Observer could have acted now to erase Lin Shen's residual consciousness. But it didn't. It looked at the nothingness. The individual once named "Lin Shen" had now melted into this 2-billion-light-year darkness, becoming space itself.

"You are not building a prison." The Observer looked at the Milky Way spinning lonely in the center of the void and suddenly understood. "You are building a Cradle."

In the universe of the Dark Forest, only the most desolate, unnoticed corners are the safest cradles for civilization's cubs.

"Recording complete." The golden light began to dissipate. "Number 9527, your case will be archived in the 'List of Abnormal Civilization Protections.' Before the void collapses, the Council will not interfere here again."

This was the greatest respect a high-dimensional being could give—Non-disturbance.

5. Wall and Sand

The Observer left. The Hall of All Souls completely collapsed, turning into a speck of dust in the lunar core. In the void, there was no response. Because Lin Shen no longer had a "self."

He no longer thought, no longer spoke, no longer had joy or sorrow. He transformed into the Wall of this two-billion-light-year wasteland, transformed into the flying Sand. His only residual function was to turn into invisible repulsion, gently and firmly pushing away all dangers attempting to approach the Milky Way.

Push away. Push away. Push away.

Like a tireless night watchman, guarding a candle flame about to go out, until the end of time.

Chapter 12: The Silent Clamor

1. The Lonely Splendor

Time Coordinate: Galactic Era Year 30,000.

Human civilization had long walked out of the solar system. The current Galaxy Federation spanned a hundred thousand light-years. Dyson spheres wrapped thousands of stars, and the glow of curvature engines connected the ends of the spiral arms like blood vessels. Humanity conquered disease, conquered aging, and even possessed demi-god-like lifespans through genetic ascension.

However, in the textbooks of this brilliant civilization, a Sword of Damocles always hung, which was also the greatest unsolved mystery in astronomy:

[The KBC Void]

No matter which direction human telescopes looked, the surroundings of the Milky Way were dead darkness. Within a diameter of two billion light-years, there were almost no galaxies, no matter, only absolute nothingness. Humans seemed trapped in a massive, empty glass bottle.

Many sociologists sighed: "This is the universe's imprisonment of humanity." Religious leaders also declared: "This is God's exile of us."

They didn't know that this was neither imprisonment nor exile. This was a doting love that lasted thirty thousand years.

2. The Purple Light at the Edge

The Federation scientific vessel Explorer was parked at the edge of the galaxy—the inner wall boundary of the "KBC Void." Captain Aisha stood in front of the huge observation window. Outside was despairing darkness, an abyss that light would take billions of years to touch bottom.

"Captain, gravity radar reaction." The first mate's voice trembled.

"What is it? Void Race? Or Observer?"

"No... it's a waveform never seen before."

On the screen, in the originally dead black void, a circle of extremely faint but vastly covering Purple Ripples suddenly appeared. It had no aggression. It was like some kind of massive breath, or a heartbeat crossing time and space.

This purple gravitational wave gently swept over the Explorer. The alarms on the ship didn't ring; instead, all crew members felt an inexplicable peace. Like a baby being gently pushed in a cradle.

"It's pushing us." Aisha looked at the readings in surprise. "It's... telling us to go home?"

The pushing force was very gentle, but irresistible. It was telling these curious children: Outside is the Dark Forest, there are wolves. Don't come out.

A little girl—Aisha's daughter—lay on the porthole, pointing at the void glowing with purple light.

"Mom, who is that?"

Aisha fell silent. She remembered the legend circulated on ancient Earth. "That is the Shepherd." She said softly. "He transformed into this wasteland so that we wouldn't be found by the wolf pack."

3. Quantum Echoes

Location: Earth-Prime (Xi'an).

Although humans had colonized the galaxy, Earth was still the holy land of civilization. In a sanatorium in Xi'an, an old woman with a head full of silver hair was sitting in a wheelchair, facing the Qinling Mountains under the setting sun. She was the Federation's famous quantum artist. Although she was two hundred years old, the oldest East Asian blood still flowed in her genes.

Her name was Xu Ling. It was said she was the N-th generation direct descendant of that Xu Weiyang from thirty thousand years ago.

Today, her mood was strange. From the morning, she had been looking at the sky and shedding tears. Doctors couldn't find any physiological problems; that sadness seemed to come from the depths of her genes, from a "phantom memory" that had been deleted but left an entangled state at the quantum level.

"Grandma Xu, what are you looking at?" The caregiver squatted down and asked.

"I'm waiting for someone." Xu Ling's voice was old and hoarse. "Although I don't know who he is, nor do I remember his name. But he seems... to be very late."

4. Sketch of the Soul

Night fell. Tonight's starry sky was particularly sparse—because of the existence of the KBC Void, Earth's night sky was much dimmer than thirty thousand years ago. But in Xu Ling's cloudy eyes, what she saw wasn't darkness.

Her trembling hand picked up a paintbrush. In a state close to channeling, she painted madly on the canvas. She didn't paint spaceships, didn't paint Dyson spheres, didn't paint those grand future technologies. She painted an ancient street from the early 21st century. She painted the Pagoda trees by the roadside, painted the blinding sunlight.

In the center of the painting, there was a Black Silhouette. That silhouette had no facial features, only an outline. But he opened his arms, like a silent wall, and also like a hugging posture, blocking the wind, rain, and starlight filling the sky. Behind this silhouette was a girl riding an electric scooter, going away without a worry.

Xu Ling finished the last stroke. In that instant, a Quantum Entanglement Current crossing thirty thousand years of time, crossing the boundary between life and death, man and god, hit her. She finally understood what that inexplicable sadness was. It was forgotten love.

"So..."

Xu Ling touched the black silhouette on the canvas, tears dripping onto the black paint, blooming into a mark like a nebula.

"So we were never lonely."

"You were always there."

5. Epilogue

Deep in the void. That purple gravitational wave pulsed once again, as if responding to the old woman's whisper.

Then, it returned to silence.